



SMOKE rises from Grand Canyon National Park in Arizona on Aug. 12. The fire now exceeds 145,000 acres. MIKAYLA WHITMORE For The Times

HOW A ‘GOOD FIRE’ WENT BAD IN GRAND CANYON



Cannabis tax cut may hinder child care

By Jenny Gold

A fight over taxes consumers pay for cannabis products has prompted a standoff between unusual adversaries: child-care advocates and the legal weed industry.

On July 1, California's cannabis excise tax in-

creased from 15% to 19% as part of a political deal struck in 2022 to help stabilize the fledgling legal market. But the industry now says the increase is untenable as it faces a sharp decline in revenue and unfair competition from the growing illicit market.

An industry-sponsored bill moving through the Leg-

islature — and already passed by the Assembly — would eliminate the tax increase and lower the rate back to 15% for the next six years. This would reduce by \$180 million annually the tax revenue that the state contributes toward law enforcement, child care, services for at-risk youth and environmental cleanup.

The losses include about \$81 million annually that would have specifically funded additional subsidized child-care slots for about 8,000 children from low-income families.

“They are choosing the cannabis industry over children and youth,” said Mary Ignatius, executive director [See Cannabis, A10]

Turning to nature for post-wildfire soil detox

After the January blazes, homeowners explore DIY ways to expel contaminants.

By Lila Seidman

Serina Diniega always wanted to plant an avocado tree at her Altadena home, but now she worries the creamy green fruit might pose a threat.

Her yard was scorched in the Eaton fire as her block went up in flames. The planetary scientist's house survived, but unseen contaminants could be lurking in the soil.

“What can I do to keep that tree healthy, hopefully be able to eat the fruit a number of years down the line without worrying about whether or not I’m poisoning my family?” she wondered. The internet was full of opinions, but science was

scarce.

So when a DIY soil detoxification workshop came up at a local nursery, she jumped on it. Many others did too; roughly 40 people were wait-listed for the three-hour class led by SoilWise, a landscaping, education and consulting business. Once a niche subject, the firestorms of January have put a spotlight on soil health, as residents wonder if their yards are safe for their children to play or if their home-grown tomatoes are OK to eat.

Learning how plants, compost and other materials combat contamination can be a source of empowerment in the face of disasters that are beyond individual control, and proponents say the approach is more environmentally friendly than conventional alternatives. For some, the tools are also a backstop against inadequate government help.

[See Soil, A11]

Menendez audio roils hearing

Recording causes a stir in Lyle Menendez's parole proceeding. His bid is denied. CALIFORNIA, B1

Abrego Garcia free — for now

U.S. plans to deport him to Uganda after he rejects a plea deal that would have sent him to Costa Rica. NATION, A6

Here's what to watch this fall

The Times staff breaks down can't-miss TV shows and movies. ENTERTAINMENT FALL PREVIEW, E1

Weather

Mostly sunny, warm. L.A. Basin: 89/69. B8

Opinion Voices A15

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A mom's hard choice after a pot farm raid

To avoid jail, deported fieldworker has to take U.S.-born kids with her

By Patrick J. McDonnell
REPORTING FROM YOJUELA, MEXICO



LILIANA NIETO DEL RIO For The Times
MODESTA MATÍAS AQUINO with her children at the Central del Norte bus station in Mexico City.

Modesta Matías Aquino was working her regular morning shift — 3 a.m. till noon — at the Glass House Farms in Camarillo, caring for rows of marijuana plants.

Among her co-workers on the morning of July 10 were two of her daughters, ages 16 and 19.

“With everything going on, with the raids, there had been rumors that something bad might happen,” Matías recalled.

About 9 a.m., she said, phalanxes of masked agents in tactical vests sealed off the sprawling compound. Matías and her daughters were among more than 300 undocumented immigrants — including at least 10 minors — who, according to U.S. authorities, were detained at a pair of Glass House sites.

The raids, like other such operations across the United States, split many so-called mixed-status families, those with both U.S.-born citizens — often children — and undocumented relatives, typically one or both parents.

Matías' family life is, by any definition, complicated. [See Choice, A4]

State voters disapprove of ICE policies

Most respondents in California poll have strong reactions to enforcement tactics.

By Andrea Castillo

Most California voters strongly disapprove of the Trump administration's immigration enforcement policies and believe that raids in the state have unfairly targeted Latinos, according to a new poll.

The findings, released Sunday, reflected striking emotional reactions to immigration enforcement. When voters were asked to describe their feelings about news reports or videos of im-

migration raids, 64% chose rage or sadness “because what is happening is unfair.”

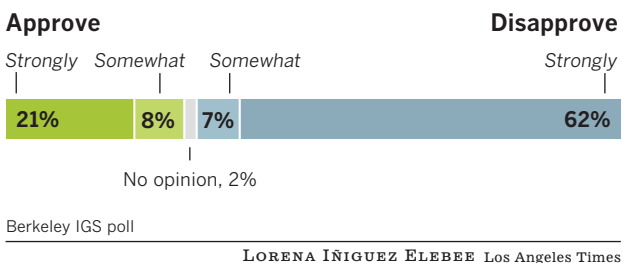
Among Democrats, 91% felt enraged or sad. Conversely, 65% of Republicans felt hopeful, “like justice is finally being served.”

Such divisions were consistent across 11 questions about the administration's overall immigration strategy and specific aspects of the way enforcement is playing out in the state, with divisions along partisan lines. The UC Berkeley Institute of Governmental Studies poll was conducted for the Los Angeles Times.

Democrats almost unanimously oppose President Trump's tactics on immigration, the poll showed. [See Voters, A9]

Trump's immigration strategy

Among registered voters, more disapprove of how the president's immigration enforcement strategy is being carried out in California.



In the Trump era, quick on the draw

California's fast push for new maps reflects the hyper-partisanship over redistricting.

By Kevin Rector, David G. Savage, Melody Gutierrez and Laura J. Nelson

In an evening social media post about a supremely partisan battle that could reshape American political power for generations, President Trump sounded ebullient.

“Big WIN for the Great State of Texas!!! Everything

Passed, on our way to FIVE more Congressional seats and saving your Rights, your Freedoms, and your Country, itself,” Trump wrote, of the nation's most populous red state pushing a mid-decade redistricting plan designed to win more Republican seats in Congress and protect Trump's power through the 2026 midterms.

“Texas never lets us down. Florida, Indiana, and others are looking to do the same thing,” Trump wrote — nodding to a potential proliferation of such efforts across the country.

The next day, Gov. Gavin Newsom — projecting a [See Era, A7]

MIXED FEELINGS: Bid to redraw California's political maps divides original drafters. **PERSPECTIVES, A2**
‘BIG BEAUTIFUL MAP’: Texas governor says he's ready to sign GOP redistricting bill. **NATION, A7**